

Frankenmonster's Compendium

Players: 3 players / **Time:** 60-90 minutes / **Age:** 13+

(I am sure you can play this with someone younger, but I haven't tested that theory yet. Let me know if you do!)

Theme

Dr. Frankenstein has created many monsters throughout the years. However, there were three that always stood out the most. These three were so fascinated with the concept of creation that they wanted to create something themselves! After years of contemplating, they decided to conduct the ultimate experiment ...create a Compendiumonster! To create such a beast would require each monster to perform multiple, smaller experiments.

Of course, only the best results from each smaller experiment should be used towards the ultimate experiment. Thus, the three monsters turned this creation process into a competition. The prize? Whoever has the best results across all of the experiments will get to name the Compendiumonster!

Game Overview

Frankenmonster's Compendium (FC) is an advanced compendium¹ trick taker.

Unlike most compendium games, the contracts are not determined at the beginning of the game. Instead, players take turns creating a contract. Then, over the course of the game, players will play through all of the created contracts. After all players complete the same contract, scores will be compared. Whoever ranks highest in that contract will gain game points and whoever ranks lowest will lose game points. The game ends after all contracts have been completed by all players. The player with the most game points wins!

¹*If you are unfamiliar with the term compendium, I recommend you check out one of my other beginner level compendiums, **Stepping Stones** or **Speed Run**, first!*

Components

- 36 playing cards (four suits, each suit is ranked 1-9)
- 1 Head Monster/In The Lab Card
- 1 Card Ranking Reminder Card
- 1 Trump Suit Reminder Card
- 3 Player Color Reminder Cards
- 3 Player Aid Cards
- 12 Overbid tokens (4 for each player, in their player color)
- 3 Reconduct tokens (1 for each player, in their player color)
- ?? Research Cards (separated into 3 decks; Deck A, Deck B, and Deck C)
- Scoresheet (you will need a pen/pencil to write on the scoresheet)

Trick Taking/Compendium Jargon Explained

Forehand: The player that starts the 'Selecting an Experiment' phase. In FC, this is referred to as the **Head Monster**.

Contracts: These define the rules surrounding the trick play, objectives, trump suit, and card ranking for the hand. In FC, these are referred to as **Experiments**.

Declarer: The player that decides which experiment is being conducted. In FC, this is referred to as **Experimenter**.

Defenders: The two players that are playing against the experimenter. In FC, this is referred to as **Observers**.

In the barrel: When the head monster is forced into becoming the experimenter. In FC, this is referred to as **In the lab**.

Trick: In clockwise order, each player plays a card from hand to the table face up.

Lead player: The player who plays the first card to a trick.

Follow player: The players who play a card to the trick after the lead player.

Led suit: The suit (color) of the card played by the lead player.

Trump suit: A suit that is stronger than the other three suits. It does not appear in every contract, but when it does, the suit is determined before the first trick.

There will be additional terms used on certain research cards (Must Follow, Must Beat, Must Play Clubs, Must Sequence, etc.), but those will be explained in more detail in the Research Card Appendix.

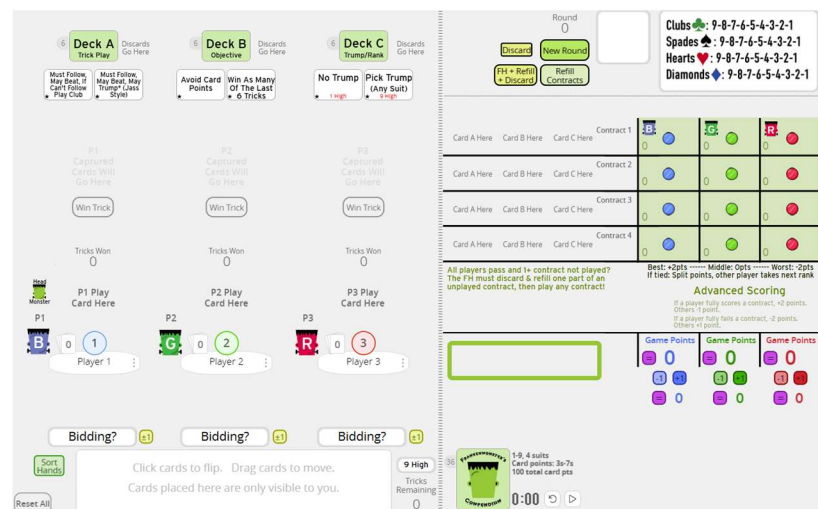
Game Setup

- Separately shuffle each research deck (A, B, and C) face down. Then, flip over the top 2 research cards from each deck and place them directly below their deck (this area will be referred to as the **hypothesis area** moving forward).

For your first game, it is recommended to use the starter cards, labeled with a star (★). There are other mix-n-match experiments you can use in future games.

- With the exception of the overbid and reconduct tokens, place the rest of the components nearby. **Overbidding and reconducting will not be in your first game.**

- The first person to ask "*Who starts?*", "*Who goes first?*", or something similar will be the head monster. Give that player the head monster card.

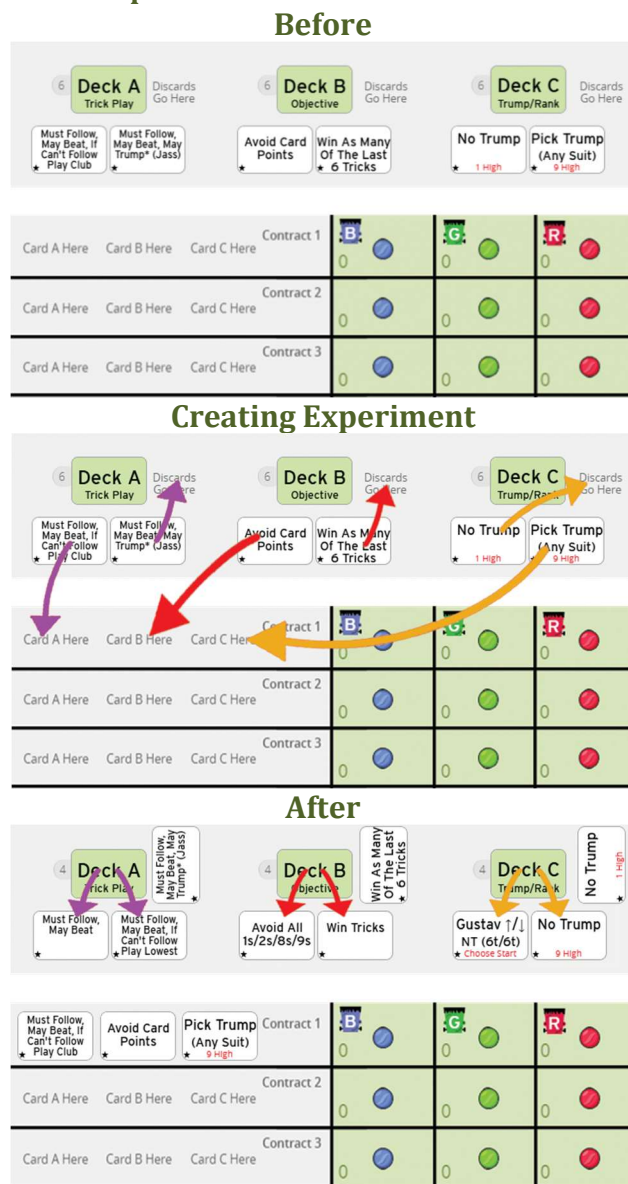


Experiment Setup

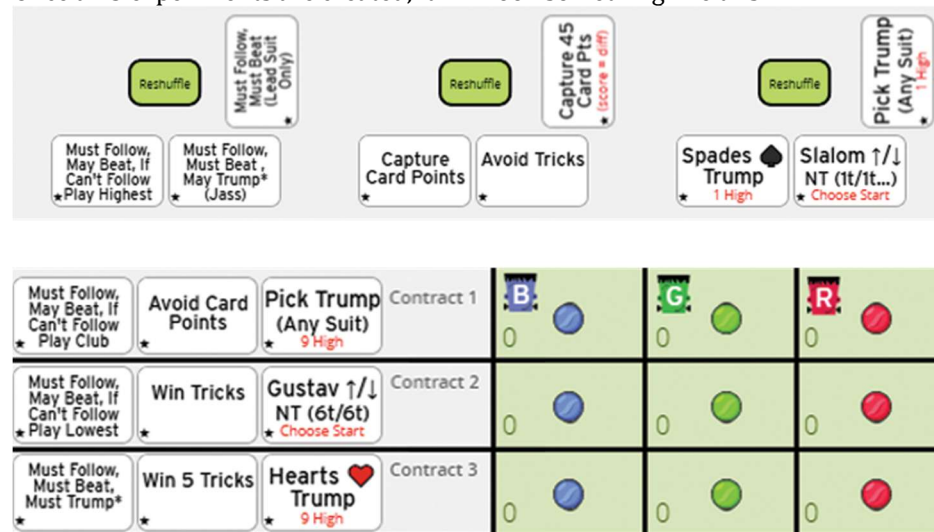
Starting with the head monster and going clockwise, each player will create an experiment, until 3 experiments are created (4 in full game, see page 8).

To create an experiment, a player must select 1 of the 2 face up research cards from each deck (1 from A, 1 from B, and 1 from C) in the hypothesis area. The research cards not selected from each deck are discarded and 2 new research cards from each deck are flipped over and placed below their deck.

Experiment 1 Example:



Once all 3 experiments are created, it will look something like this.



Note: Created experiments could change during the game. That is why two research cards are flipped over from each deck even after the last experiment is created!

Gameplay

FC is played over 9 hands (12 in a full game, see page 8 for more info).

A hand will consist of 4 main phases in the following order:

- 1) Dealing
- 2) Selecting an Experiment
- 3) Trick Taking
- 4) End of Hand Scoring

1) Dealing

At the beginning of each hand, the head monster will shuffle the deck and deal 12 cards to each player, face down. Players take their 12 cards into hand, making sure to keep them hidden from the other players.

2) Selecting an Experiment

Starting with the head monster and going clockwise, each player may select an experiment to conduct or pass. **You cannot select an experiment that you have already conducted this game!**

When selecting an experiment, you simply say which experiment you want to conduct along with any additional information that is required (page 6).

As soon as a player selects an experiment, they become the experimenter, the selection phase ends, 'Research Replacement' does not happen, and play proceeds to the trick taking phase.

Passing:

If a player passes, they no longer participate in the selection phase (hard pass).

What happens if all players pass?

It is possible that all three players pass in a row during the selection phase. If that happens, the head monster is “put in the lab”. This means they become the experimenter and must select an experiment they have not conducted yet. However, this selection only comes after the head monster checks to see if there are any experiments that have been not been conducted by **any** player.

- If there are any, proceed to ‘Research Replacement’ below.
- If all experiments have been conducted at least once by any player, proceed to the trick taking phase. Additionally, you will skip the ‘Research Replacement’ step for the rest of the game. Return all research cards that are not part of your current experiments back to the box.

Important: You will NEVER replace part of an experiment that has already been conducted by any player! In other words, once a contract has been played by someone the other two players must play the exact same contract.

Research Replacement:

The head monster must perform these steps in order:

- 1) Choose a non-conducted experiment (if there are multiple to choose from)
- 2) Discard one research card from the chosen experiment
- 3) Replace the discarded card with one of the face up research cards in the hypothesis area that matches the deck of the discarded card.
- 4) Flip over the top research card from the matching deck to replace the one that was just taken. If the deck is empty, shuffle the discard pile into a new deck.
- 5) Select an experiment to conduct that they have not conducted yet. **It does not need to be the experiment where the research card was just replaced!**

Research Replacement Example:

Step 1) Demetri, Cindy, and Sarah have all passed during the selection phase. Demetri, the head monster, is put in the lab and must select an experiment. Before selecting, he must determine if any experiments have not been conducted by any player. Experiments 1 and 2 have been, but experiment 3 has not. Therefore, he must replace one research card from experiment 3.

Step 2) Demetri selects the ‘Win 5 Tricks’ research card (which is from Deck B) and discards it.
Step 3) Demetri must replace the discarded research card with another research card from the two face up options from the same deck (Deck B). He chooses ‘Avoid Tricks’.

Step 4) Demetri must flip over a new research card so Deck B has two face up options again. However, the deck is empty, so he shuffles the discard pile into a new draw pile. Then he draws and flips over a new research card from the top of the deck.
Demetri must now select experiment 2 or 3 (the two experiments he has left to conduct). If he selects experiment 3, the hypothesis area would be removed from the game. This is because, after this hand, all experiments will have been conducted at least once by any player.

Additional Information:

If the experimenter selects an experiment that requires additional information they must provide it the moment they select the experiment.
The two most common bits of information will be card ranking and trump suit.

Card ranking

They must announce if 9s will be the highest rank or if 1s will be highest.
When 9s are the highest rank, the card ranking is 9>8>7>6>5>4>3>2>1.
When 1s are the highest rank, the card ranking is 1>2>3>4>5>6>7>8>9.

Trump suit

They must announce one of the four suits to be the trump suit for the hand.

There are more research cards that will require other kinds of additional information. Please see the Research Card Appendix for more on those.

3) Trick Taking

- The trick play, objective, trump suit, and card ranking will all change drastically based on the research cards used in a specific experiment. *Refer to the Research Card Appendix for more information on how each card impacts the experiment.*
- The experimenter will always be the lead player for the first trick. The winner of the current trick will be the lead player for the next trick.
- When a player wins a trick, they must collect all cards and place them in a facedown pile in front of themselves. If the experimenter wins multiple tricks, make sure to keep the piles separate so all players can easily tell how many tricks the experimenter has won throughout the hand. The observers can stack their tricks into a single pile as their trick wins do not matter for scoring.

After all 12 tricks have been played proceed to End of Hand Scoring.

4) End of Hand Scoring

Only the experimenter's score will be calculated for the hand! The observers are trying to win (or lose) tricks, card points, etc. to have the experimenter perform poorly during their experiment. But ultimately, the experimenter is the only player to score in an individual hand.

Based on the objective, the experimenter should write the number they got for it in their score box matching that experiment number.

Must Follow, May Beat, If Can't Follow ★ Play Lowest	Win Tricks	Gustav ↑/↓ NT (6t/6t) ★ Choose Start	Contract 2	0	7	6
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Example) Sarah was the experimenter this hand and her objective was to win as many tricks as possible. She won 6 tricks. So, she writes down "6" in her column for experiment 2.

Experiment Results (Game Points):

If an experiment has been conducted by all players it is time to give out results.

Results are the actual score to the game.

- The player that did the best at meeting the experiment's objective ranks first and scores **+3 results**.
- The player that did the worst ranks last and scores **-1 result**.
- The middle player scores **+1 result**.

If there is a tie, the tied players split the points between the two ranks. The other player scores full points for the final ranking.

Tied for first = Both players +2 results / Other player -1 result

Tied for last = Both players 0 results / Other player +3 results

In the rare situation where all players tie for rank, then all players score **1 result**.

Must Follow, May Beat, If Can't Follow ★ Play Lowest	Win Tricks	Gustav ↑/↓ NT (6t/6t) ★ Choose Start	Contract 2	Demetri 4 -1	Cindy 7 1	Sarah 6 3
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Example: After a few hands, all players have conducted experiment 2. The objective for this experiment was to win as many tricks as possible. Demetri won 4 tricks, Cindy won 7, and Sarah won 6. Cindy ranks first and scores +3 results, Sarah ranks middle and scores 1 result, and Demetri ranks last and scores -1 result.

Starting a New Hand

If there are any experiments left to conduct, start a new hand by performing the following steps in order:

1) Pass the head monster token clockwise **until it reaches a player that has not conducted all of their experiments**.

Important: If a player has already conducted all of their experiments, they can no longer be the head monster or the experimenter. This means they cannot participate in the 'Selecting an Experiment' phase and must permanently pass when it would be their turn to select. **However, they will participate in every other phase of the game as normal.**

2) The new head monster collects all playing cards and shuffles them together.

3) Repeat the 4 main phases of the game (starts on page 4).

If all experiments have been conducted by all players, go to End of Game.

End of Game

After all experiments are completed, each player should add (or subtract) all of their results across all experiments. It is possible to have a negative score.

The player will the highest positive score wins and has earned the right to name the Compendiummonster that was created before their very eyes!

If there is a tie, the player with the highest total across all experiments wins.

To determine this total, add (or subtract) all of the objective totals in a player's column. Positive objectives are added, while negative objectives are subtracted.

If still tied, the player that completed all of their experiments first wins.

Advanced Rules & Variants

When playing for the first time, all rules listed before this section are the recommended rules to play with. However, players are free to choose which advanced rules or variants they would like to play with at any time. They are all modular, but all players should agree on which ones they use before the game.

- Full Game (Advanced Rule)

All rules are the same as the base game, except for the following:

A full game consists of 4 experiments (12 hands) instead of 3 (9 hands).

The first 3 experiments are created the same way as described earlier. However, the 4th experiment will be created collaboratively between the three players.

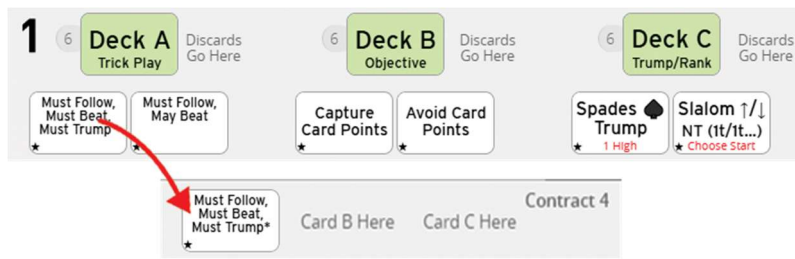
- Starting with the head monster and going clockwise, each player will select 1 of the 2 research cards from one of the decks, following these steps in order:

1) The head monster must select 1 card from deck A, B, or C.

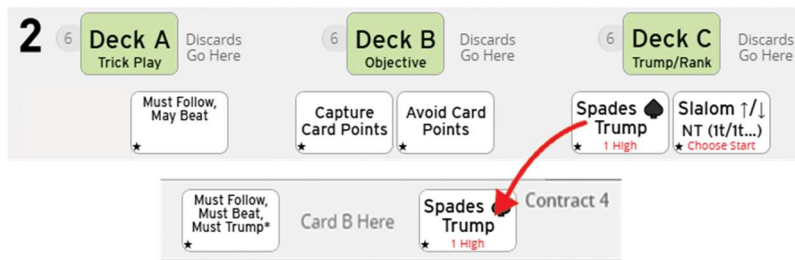
2) The next player must select 1 card from the deck that the head monster did not select from.

3) The last player must select 1 card from the remaining deck.

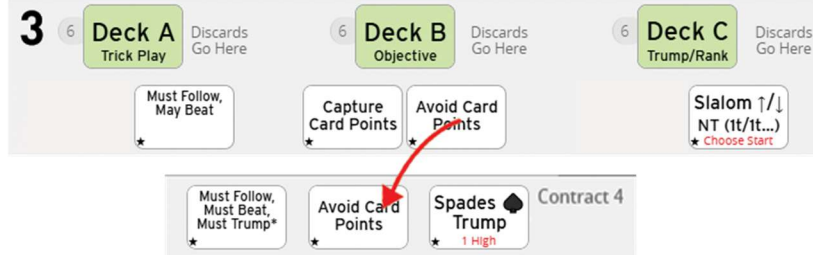
Experiment 4 Creation Example



Step 1) Demetri is head monster and can select from any deck. He selects a card from deck A.



Step 2) Cindy is next and can only select from decks B or C. She selects a card from deck C.



Step 3) Sarah is last and can only select a card from deck B, so that is what she does.

- Overbidding (Advanced Rule)

All rules are the same as the base game, except for the following:

Game Setup:

- During game setup, give each player four overbid tokens.

Selecting an Experiment:

Players may overbid during the 'Selecting an Experiment' phase. Overbidding occurs when two or more players want to select an experiment in the same hand.

Reminder: If a player passes, they no longer participate in this phase.

The first time any player selects an experiment they do not need to overbid. However, if there are any subsequent selections, those will require overbidding. To overbid, select the experiment you want to conduct and place 1 overbid token more than the previous player next to your selected experiment. Meaning, the first overbid would require 1 overbid token, the second overbid would require 2 overbid tokens, third requires 3 tokens, and fourth requires 4 tokens.

If you do not have enough tokens to overbid, you cannot overbid and must pass. When you pass, you must take back any overbid tokens you have placed this phase. You will be able to use them again in future hands.

When overbidding, players may select the same or different experiment as another player. However, a player cannot change their experiment choice. Once you select an experiment this hand, it's that experiment or bust!

After two players pass, the remaining player becomes the experimenter and returns any overbid tokens they spent back to the box. Gameplay proceeds as normal from there.

- Reconduct Experiments (Advanced Rule)

Additional Background For This Rule

Most compendium games, by nature, are all about timing. For each experiment, you do not need to have a perfect score. You just need to have a better score than your friends! So knowing when it is the right time to select an experiment and the right time to pass are very important decisions to make if you want to do well. Of course, there are times where you are forced to select (pushed into in lab) or you select something and things didn't go your way. Well, this rule is a way for players to have one chance to redo a contract that they might have done poorly in. **Please note, this variant can cause the game to be up to 3 hands longer. So, while it is a friendlier variant, it can also make the game longer!**

All rules are the same as the base game, except for the following:

Game Setup:

- During game setup, give each player one reconduct token.

Selecting an Experiment:

- When selecting an experiment, a player may spend their reconduct token (return it to the box) to redo any experiment they have previously conducted.
- A player can use their reconduct as long as the game is not over. Meaning, as long as there is one experiment that is not conducted, from any player, a reconduct token may be spent.

End of Hand Scoring:

- If a player does better than their original attempt they update their "Objective Total" amount, on the scoresheet, to the new amount.

Win Tricks Example: Cindy won 5 tricks the first time she did the contract. She spent her reconduct token and won 8 tricks this time. So, she updates her scoresheet to say '8'.

- If a player does worse than their original attempt they keep their original "Objective Total" amount.

Avoid Card Points Example: Cindy captured 36 card points the first time she did the contract. She spent her reconduct and captured 36 card points this time. So, she does not change the scoresheet.

Starting a New Hand:

- When passing the head monster token, do not skip a player that has conducted all of their experiments **and still has their reconduct token!** If that player has already spent their reconduct token, then you must skip them as normal.

- Fully Collaborative Experiment Setup (Variant)

All rules are the same as the base game, except for the following:

Experiment Setup:

All experiments are created collaboratively between the three players. To understand the rules around collaboratively creating experiments, follow the steps provided under **Full Game (Advanced Rule)** (pages 8-9).

Pass the head monster token clockwise after creating an experiment. This allows each player to get at least one contract where they select 1st/2nd/3rd.

- Quicker Experiment Setup (Variant)

All rules are the same as the base game, except for the following:

Experiment Setup:

Instead of players creating the experiments, randomly shuffle the research cards (keeping the decks separate) and reveal one card from each deck for each experiment.

Designer Note: While this variant is not something that I truly recommended, I do recognize some players may want a faster setup...especially during their first few plays. There are 2 reasons why I do not recommend this setup.

*1) It feels more personal and tells a better story when players are given the choice of creating the experiments. Even if you have no idea how the research cards will truly work, you can still have a gut feeling of what **could be** fun, interesting, silly, etc. During the game you can all say "Dang, Mary you really created a wacky experiment!" or "Holy smokes Dave, your experiment was the hardest, but like, in a good way." Random experiments don't have the same personal connection.*

2) If you completely randomize setup, you may end up with some boring or even borderline impossible experiment combinations. Then, you all have to spend a hand passing to trigger Research Replacement to fix them anyway. It is much harder for players to accidentally create experiments like this. Or, at least if they do, it's funnier when you can side-eye them for it vs the game randomly doing it.

All of that said, it is your game to play/discover. So, if you want to randomly set up the experiments I totally get it. Either way, thanks for playing the game!

Credits

Designer and Rulebook Writer: Ryan Campbell

Artist: Michelle Campbell...at some point

Playtesters: Carol LaGrow, Daniel Newman, Danielle Verba, David Spalinski, Derrick Smith, Emmy Caldwell, Jered Tupik, Keith Cerroni, Sarah Geiger, Melanie Campbell, Michelle Mi-Sun Choi, Neil Campbell, Shreesh Bhat, Srinivas Vasudevan

Quick Start/Refresher Guide

Setup Experiments (3 in a short game, 4 in a full game):

Starting with the head monster and going clockwise, each player will create an experiment, until all experiments are created.

To create an experiment, a player must select 1 of the 2 face up research cards from each deck (1 from A, 1 from B, and 1 from C) in the hypothesis area. The research cards not selected from each deck are discarded and 2 new research cards from each deck are flipped over and placed below their deck.

A hand will consist of 4 phases in the following order:

- | | |
|-----------------|----------------------------|
| 1) Dealing | 2) Selecting an Experiment |
| 3) Trick Taking | 4) End of Hand Scoring |

1) Dealing

Deal 12 cards per player.

2) Selecting an Experiment

Starting with the head monster and going clockwise, select an experiment or pass. Once a player selects an experiment they become the experimenter and this phase ends.

If all players pass, the head monster is forced to become the experimenter and checks for Research Replacement (page 5) before proceeding to phase 3.

3) Trick Taking

Experimenter leads first trick. Winner of the current trick leads next trick. Trick play, objective, trump, and card ranking is set based on the research card for the experiment. After all 12 tricks are played, proceed to phase 4.

4) End of Hand Scoring

Only the experimenter's score will be calculated for the hand!

The experimenter records their objective amount on the scoresheet matching the experiment they conducted.

Pass the head monster card clockwise, skipping any players that have conducted their experiments. Repeat phases until all experiments are completed.